Reported speech

Objective: To report statements, questions and orders in indirect speech, applying the changes of tense, pronouns and time expressions.

The idea in two lines: In reported speech we tell what someone said without quoting their exact words. When the reporting verb is in the past (*said, told, asked*), the tense usually moves **one step back**.

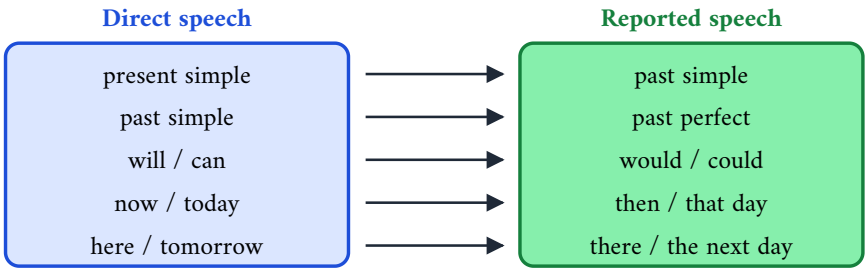


Figure 1: The main backshift of tenses and changes of time and place expressions after a past reporting verb.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Statements:** said (that) / told someone (that) + clause: *"I am tired."* → *He said (that) he was tired.*
2. **Backshift:** present → past; past and present perfect → past perfect; will → would; can → could; may → might.
3. **Pronouns and possessives** change according to the speaker: *I* → *he / she, my* → *his / her.*
4. **Yes/no questions:** asked + if / whether + subject + verb (no question form): *She asked if I liked news.*
5. **Wh- questions:** asked + wh-word + subject + verb: *He asked where I lived.*
6. **Orders and requests:** told / asked + object + (not) to + base form: *She told me not to shout.*

🟢 Examples

1. "I will write the article tomorrow," the journalist said. **Answer:** The journalist said (that) he *would write* the article *the next day*.
2. "Did you read the news?" Sara asked me. **Answer:** Sara asked me *if I had read* the news. **Explanation:** past simple → past perfect, no auxiliary did.
3. "Close the window," the teacher said to us. **Answer:** The teacher *told us to close* the window.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Keeping the question form: *He asked where did I live* ✗ → **where I lived** ✓.
- Using *said me* ✗: we say **told me** or **said to me**.
- Forgetting to change pronouns and time expressions.
- Keeping quotation marks or the question mark in reported speech.

🟡 Quick review

- One tense back after a past reporting verb.
- Questions: if / whether or wh- + normal word order.
- Orders: told + object + (not) to + verb.
- Change pronouns, time and place words.

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